



The meaning you are looking for

Why success doesn't fill you, and what to do with the emptiness that remains.

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*This ebook is a self-knowledge and
existential reflection resource. It does
not replace therapeutic support. If you
experience persistent emptiness or
loss of meaning, please seek
professional help.*

1. You have everything and feel that something is missing

I'm going to describe a scene to you. If it isn't exactly yours, it will be close enough that you'll recognize it.

It's a Tuesday. Or a Thursday. Any ordinary day, because emptiness doesn't choose special dates to appear. You came home after a day that went well. Nothing bad happened. No one offended you, no one disappointed you, nothing broke. The children are fine. Work is stable. The house is more or less tidy. Life is, on the surface, in its place.

And yet.

You sit at the table, or on the sofa, or on the edge of the bed, and you feel it. Not exactly sadness. Not anger. Not tiredness, though the tiredness is also there, as it always is. Something else. A kind of translucent weight that can't be seen but that can be felt. A question that doesn't form in words but that occupies space in the chest.

"Is this it?"

You don't ask it aloud. You may never have said it to anyone. But it's there. And it appears in the most unexpected moments. In the middle of a dinner with friends, when you laugh at a joke and notice the laughter drains away before it reaches the bottom. On Sunday morning, when you look out the window and have everything you need to be at peace, and the peace doesn't come. In the car, driving home from work, when you turn off the radio and are left with the silence, and the silence weighs.

"Is this who I am? Is this what life is? Is this what I worked so hard for?"

Maybe you have the job you wanted. Or at least a decent job, one that pays the bills, gives you some autonomy. Maybe you have the house, the car, the children, the partner. Maybe you've achieved things your mother never achieved. Maybe you are, by any external measure, in a position many people would envy.

And it's precisely for that reason that you don't talk about this.

Because how do you explain that you have everything and feel that something is missing? How do you tell someone, without seeming ungrateful, that the life you built doesn't fulfill you? That the diploma han-

ging on the wall didn't give you the satisfaction it promised? That the raise you received gave you a month of relief and then the emptiness returned, intact, as if it had never left?

You don't say it. Because it seems obscene. It seems like ingratitude. And ingratitude is perhaps the accusation we fear most, especially when we know there are people with lives far more difficult than ours.

And so you do what so many of us do: you stay quiet. And you find more things to do. More goals. More lists. More projects. More training courses. More achievements that might give you that sensation of purpose, that brief moment when everything seems to make sense. And it works. For a while. Until the moment when you sit in silence again and the question returns.

I know this feeling. I know it from within, not only from study. There was a period in my life when everything was "fine" and I couldn't understand why "fine" wasn't enough. I did more. Studied more. Cared more. Organized more. And the more was never enough. Not because there wasn't enough effort, but because the effort was pointed in the wrong direction. I was trying to fill with action what asked for contemplation. Trying to solve with productivity what needed meaning.

And the worst of it was the shame. The shame of feeling that it wasn't enough. Because there were people around me with infinitely more difficult lives, with real, concrete, urgent problems. And me, with everything "fine," feeling this hole. It seemed like a whim. It seemed like ingratitude. It seemed like I was inventing a problem where there was none. And that shame was a second layer of weight on top of the first. Not only did I feel empty: I felt guilty for feeling empty.

If you recognize this, I want to tell you something no one told me at the time, something that would have made a difference: the emptiness is not ingratitude. The emptiness is the voice of that part of you that knows there is more. That knows life is not only logistics, routine, the fulfilling of tasks. That knows, with a certainty that needs no proof, that something essential has been left unlived. And that voice doesn't go silent with more activity, more achievements, more distractions. It goes silent only when you listen to it.

And perhaps you're thinking: "But do I have depression? Is that what this is?"

It's a legitimate question. And I want to treat it with the seriousness it deserves, because there is a zone where existential emptiness and depression overlap, and it's important to know the difference.

Depression is a clinical condition. It has identifiable symptoms: persistent loss of pleasure, changes in sleep and appetite, profound fatigue, difficulty concentrating, feelings of worthlessness or excessive guilt, sometimes thoughts about death. If you recognize several of these signs in yourself, persistently, please seek professional help. There is no shame in that whatsoever. There is courage.

Existential emptiness is something else. You can function perfectly well. You can laugh, work, love, care. But at the bottom of all of that there is a question that finds no answer. It's not that you can't feel pleasure. It's that pleasure doesn't feel like enough. It's not that you're sinking. It's that you're floating, and floating doesn't take you anywhere.

Viktor Frankl, the psychiatrist who survived Auschwitz and dedicated his life to the study of meaning, called this "existential vacuum." He didn't see it as a disease. He saw it as a condition of modern human experience. He said that each era has its collective neuroses, and that ours is not sexual repression (as in Freud's time), nor inferiority (as in Adler's), but the absence of meaning. The feeling that one can have everything and still have nothing that truly matters.

He wrote this in the nineteen-sixties. Look at the world now. Abundance has multiplied. Options have multiplied. Information has multiplied. And the feeling of emptiness too.

I'm not romanticizing suffering. I'm not saying that those who have less suffer less. I'm saying that meaning doesn't live in achievements. And when we confuse it with success, we're asking one thing to give us what only another thing can provide. It's like being thirsty and eating. The food can be wonderful. But the thirst remains.

If you've made it this far and feel I'm describing something you know, I want you to understand: you are not being ungrateful. You are not being weak. You are not inventing a problem where there is none. You are feeling something profoundly human, profoundly real, and profoundly important.

The question "is this it?" is not a defect. It's a calling. It's your soul (if you'll allow me the word) telling you there is something more. Not more in the sense of quantity. More in the sense of depth.

And that is what this book is about. I'm not going to give you a packaged answer. I'm not going to tell you what the meaning of your life is, because that would be a lie and a violence. The meaning of your life is yours, and yours alone, and no one has the right to tell you what it is. What I will do is walk with you to the place where meaning is built. Show you where this emptiness comes from. Show you why success

doesn't fill it. And show you, with honesty and without magic recipes, what the psychology of meaning, Transpersonal Psychology, and my own experience have taught me about what truly fills.

Not as an answer. As a path.

Come with me. Not as a student, not as a patient. As someone who also feels this question, sitting beside someone who felt it before you and decided not to look away.

2. The promise that success doesn't keep

When you were small, someone made you a promise. Not in those words, perhaps. Not directly. But the message reached you, clear as water, through everything around you.

The promise was this: if you work hard, if you're a good student, if you get your degree, if you get a good job, if you build a stable life, you will be happy.

Do you remember? It wasn't just your family saying it. It was the school. The teachers who rewarded effort and punished distraction. The movies, the series, the stories you read. The heroine struggles, suffers, persists, and in the end is rewarded. The narrative arc is always the same: effort, overcoming, reward. And the reward is happiness.

We grew up with this idea implanted so deeply that we don't even recognize it as an idea. We think it's reality. We think that's how life works: first effort, then reward. First struggle, then peace. First achievement, then fulfillment.

And we kept going. We studied. We got good grades, or fought for them. We got our degrees, or another degree, or a master's, or yet another course. We found work. We climbed. We achieved positions. We built things: houses, businesses, careers, families. And at each stage, there was a brief moment of satisfaction. A month, a week, sometimes just a day when we felt: "I did it."

But then the month ended. And life continued the same. Or rather: life continued different on the outside and the same on the inside.

You got the job you wanted. And for the first few weeks you felt fulfilled. And then you began to see the problems, the limitations, the boredom. You got the house. And for the first few months it was wonderful. And then it was just a house, with bills and maintenance and neighbors. You got the relationship. And at first it seemed like everything finally made sense. And then came the routine, the conflicts, the reality that another person doesn't complete you, regardless of what the movies promised.

And you, at each achievement that didn't fill you, did the logical thing: you looked for the next one.

This is the oldest and most effective mechanism of modern Western culture: the hedonic treadmill. The name sounds complicated, but the idea is simple. Psychology calls it the phenomenon by which we quickly adapt to any improvement in our circumstances and return to our habitual level of satisfaction (or dissatisfaction). You earn more money, and after a short time that money is the new normal, and you need more. You move house, and after a short time the new house is just the house, and something is missing. The treadmill is always running. You run, but the ground beneath you doesn't move forward.

And it's tiring. Very tiring. Because the promise said there was a finish line. A point where you could stop and say: "That's it. I made it. Now I can rest." But the line doesn't exist. Or rather: the line exists, but when you cross it, there's another one behind it. And another. And another.

And the most perverse part of all this is that you can't stop. Because if you stop, the guilt appears. "If I'm not working toward something, what am I doing?" The culture of progress doesn't allow us to simply be. You have to be going somewhere. You have to have a goal, a target, a five-year plan. And if you don't, something is wrong with you. The absence of ambition is treated almost like a clinical problem. "What do you want

from life?" they ask you, and the honest answer, "I don't know, maybe I just want this to make sense," doesn't work. It's not measurable. It doesn't fit into a goals chart. It can't go on a resume.

I want to be clear: I'm not saying success is bad. I'm not saying working, achieving, building is wrong. I'm saying success is a tool, not a destination. It's something you do, not something that fills you. And the confusion between the two is the root of immense silent suffering.

Because when you believe success should fill you and it doesn't, there are only two possible conclusions: either something is wrong with success, or something is wrong with you. And since everyone around you seems satisfied with their successes (or at least pretends to be), the conclusion you reach is the second: the problem is me.

It's not you.

The problem is the promise.

Success fills the resume. Fills the bank account. Fills other people's expectations. But it doesn't fill the place inside you that asks "why?" Because that place doesn't need achievements. It needs meaning.

And meaning and success, though they can coexist, are fundamentally different things.

Success asks: "What have I achieved?" Meaning asks: "What does this serve?"

Success asks: "How much is what I did worth?" Meaning asks: "To whom does what I did matter?"

Success is measured from the outside. Meaning is measured from within. And no amount of external success replaces the absence of inner meaning.

I want to tell you something I read many years ago and have never forgotten. A study with people in the final stage of life, who were asked what they regretted. Do you know what the most common regrets were? It wasn't "I should have worked more." It wasn't "I should have earned more money." It wasn't "I should have had more success." It was: "I should have had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me." It was: "I should have spent more time with the people I love." It was: "I should have allowed myself to be happier."

Notice: not one of these regrets is about achievement. All are about meaning. About authenticity. About presence. About connection.

And there is something particularly revealing in this study: the people who looked back with the most serenity were not those who had had the most success. They were the ones who felt their life had made sense. That they had loved well, contributed to something, been true. Some had lived simple lives. Some had gone through enormous losses. But they felt that what they had lived had mattered. Not to the world. To them.

That is the difference. Success needs an audience. Meaning doesn't. You can feel your life has meaning at three in the morning, alone, nursing a baby that no one will applaud. You can feel meaning while listening to a friend who won't post your generosity on social media. You can feel meaning when you make a difficult decision that no one will understand, but that you know to be true. Meaning doesn't need to be seen. It needs to be felt.

And this is why success doesn't fill you. Because success lives in others' gaze. And what you lack is not others' gaze. It's your own gaze inward.

The promise of success is not only unfulfilled. It is unfulfillable. Because success belongs to the world of forms, of results, of the measurable. And what you lack is not measurable. What you lack is invisible, interior, and belongs to a dimension of experience that our culture barely has language to describe.

There is a deep irony in all of this: the very search for meaning can be colonized by the logic of success. When someone tells you "you need to find your purpose" as if it were yet another goal, yet another target, yet another item to add to the list, they are applying the same logic of success to the territory of meaning. And it doesn't work. Because meaning is not conquered. It's not reached. It can't be ticked off a list. You can't "optimize" meaning the way you optimize a morning routine or a career strategy. Meaning escapes that language. It belongs to a different grammar, older, slower, more silent.

Meaning is lived. Or it isn't.

And the emptiness you feel is not the absence of good things in your life. It's the absence of a deep connection between what you do and who you are. Between what you have and what matters. Between your life as it appears on the outside and your life as you feel it on the inside.

That disconnect is the real problem. And it's what we will discuss next.

3. What existential emptiness is

Let's rest here for a moment. Because this is the part where I need to explain something that seems complicated but which, at its core, is so simple and so human that your body already knows it, even if your mind hasn't yet found the words.

Existential emptiness is not a disease. It's not a diagnosis. It's not something "wrong" with you. It is, rather, an experience. The experience of feeling that your life lacks a meaning to sustain it. That the things you do, however good or useful or necessary, are not connected to anything larger. That you wake up, function, produce, care, solve, and at the end of the day you're left with the impression that all of this could not have happened and nothing essential would have changed.

Viktor Frankl described it as "existential frustration." Not the frustration of someone who can't get what they want. The frustration of someone who gets what they want and realizes it wasn't what they needed. The frustration of someone who followed all the rules and discovers the game made no sense.

And it's important to distinguish this from other forms of suffering, because the confusion between them generates a great deal of unnecessary pain.

Sadness has an object. You are sad about something: a loss, a disappointment, a longing. Sadness, however painful, has roots. You know where it comes from. And when the root is treated (with time, with grief, with care), sadness generally eases.

Anxiety has a direction. It points toward the future, toward what might go wrong, toward the threat. It is uncomfortable, sometimes unbearable, but it has a logic: your body is trying to protect you from something.

Depression has a weight. It is as if the whole world turned grey, without color, without flavor. Energy disappears. Pleasure disappears. Will disappears. And you need help to get out of it, because alone it is nearly impossible.

Existential emptiness is different from all these things, though it can co-exist with any of them. Existential emptiness has no object, no direction, no specific weight. It has, rather, an absence. The feeling that something is missing that you cannot name. It's not that you're sad. It's

that nothing fills you. It's not that you're afraid. It's that nothing truly moves you. It's not that you can't function. It's that functioning isn't enough.

And this is the cruel part: because you can function, no one notices. Because you're not falling apart, no one worries. Because you smile, work, care, solve, everyone assumes you're fine. And you assume you should be fine, because you have reasons to be. And the distance between "you should be fine" and "you're not fine" is a silent corridor where many people walk alone for years.

Existential emptiness has patterns. There are moments in life when it appears with more force, more insistence, more urgency. It's not random.

One of those moments is what developmental psychology calls midlife, though the name is misleading, because it doesn't necessarily happen at forty or fifty. It happens when you've lived long enough to realize that the first half of your life was spent building what society told you to build, and you look at what you've built and ask: "And now?" It's the moment when the script ends and no one gives you another. School told you what to do. University told you what to do. The start of a career told you what to do. But now, when the exterior is more or less set up, no one tells you how the interior organizes itself.

Carl Jung wrote about this with remarkable clarity. He said the first half of life is for building the ego, the identity, the place in the world. But the second half is for something else: for finding what lies beyond the ego. For going to meet what he called the Self, that part of us that is larger than our personal history, larger than our roles, larger than our name. And that many of the midlife crises are not crises of aging, they are crises of meaning. The ego has built everything it knew how to build. And now it calls for something deeper to take the lead.

Another moment when existential emptiness appears with force is after a significant loss. Not necessarily a death, though death is among the most powerful. It can be the loss of a relationship, a professional identity, a phase of life. The mother whose children left home. The woman who divorced after twenty years. The person who lost the job that defined who they were. In these losses, what is lost is not only the thing or the person. What is lost is the structure of meaning that was built around it. And when the structure falls, the emptiness is exposed. Not because the emptiness appeared with the loss. It was already there. But there were things on top of it covering it over. The loss removed the covering.

And then there is a third moment, perhaps the most paradoxical of all: the emptiness that appears after you've achieved everything. After you've reached the goal. After you've crossed the finish line. It's the moment that athletes describe as a kind of post-achievement depression. It's what many women feel after having the baby they desperately wanted (beyond the hormonal baby blues, there is a deeper emptiness: "I got what I wanted most. Why don't I feel complete?"). It's what you feel when you finally buy the house, finish the project, receive the promotion, and after a brief moment of euphoria, you are exactly where you were before.

This third moment is the most silenced, because it is the hardest to justify. How do you complain about having achieved something? How do you say that a dream fulfilled left you empty? It seems absurd. It seems like ingratitude. It seems like madness.

It is none of those things. It is the nature of existential emptiness: it doesn't respond to circumstances. It responds to meaning. And you can have the best circumstances in the world and be empty of meaning. Just as you can have terrible circumstances and have a meaning so strong it sustains you even in the middle of the storm. Frankl saw this in the concentration camps: the people who had a reason to live, a meaning

(whether the love of someone, unfinished work, or faith), survived. Those who didn't gave up. Not through weakness. Because without meaning, life cannot sustain itself.

And here is something that deserves to be said with care: existential emptiness can resemble depression, and sometimes it coexists with it, but they are not the same thing. Depression is a clinical condition that needs treatment. Existential emptiness is a human condition that needs attention. If you feel depressed, if you've lost the capacity to feel pleasure, if you can't get up, if you're thinking about giving up, please seek professional help. There's no shame in that, there is courage. But if what you feel is more like a background hum, a persistent feeling that something is missing without knowing what, that life runs but doesn't sing, then it's possible that you are hearing the voice of meaning asking for your attention.

And that voice doesn't go silent with more work, more shopping, more distraction. That voice goes silent in only two ways: either you anesthetize it (and some people do that for an entire lifetime, paying the price of disconnection), or you listen to it. And listening is what we are doing here, together, in this book.

Now I want to pause and speak to you directly.

If you are reading this and thinking "this is me," I want you to know that recognizing this emptiness is, in itself, an act of courage and intelligence. Many people flee it their whole lives. They flee into overwork, into consumption, into distractions, into full agendas, into screens. They flee because the emptiness frightens them. Because stopping and feeling that something is missing is uncomfortable. Because the question "what am I here for?" is a question our culture doesn't teach us to ask, let alone answer.

But you didn't flee. You are here. You are looking at the emptiness directly. And that, in itself, is already the beginning of something different.

Because existential emptiness is not a bottomless pit. It's a door. A door that most people don't see, because it's disguised as a problem. But it's a door. And on the other side is something that has no easy name, but that I will try to describe: it's meaning. Not ready-made meaning, gift-wrapped and home-delivered. But meaning as possibility. As construction. As path.

And it's toward that path that I want to take you now.

4. Meaning is not found, it is built

There is a phrase that repeats itself in self-help books, in social media posts, in coffee conversations: "Find your purpose." It's said as if purpose were a thing that is somewhere, hidden beneath a stone or behind a door, waiting to be discovered. As if it were enough to search with sufficient dedication, attend the right retreat, read the right book, and suddenly, in a moment of illumination, everything makes sense.

I want to be honest with you: it doesn't work that way.

Meaning is not a lost object that you find. It's a house that you build. Brick by brick, day by day, choice by choice. It doesn't appear in a flash (though there are moments when it reveals itself with more clarity). It isn't given by anyone (though others can help you see it). It isn't a destination someone decided for you (though there may be something larger that invites you to walk in a certain direction).

This distinction matters, because it changes everything.

If you believe meaning is found, then until you've found it, you are incomplete. You are waiting. You are in deficit. And every day that passes without finding it is another wasted day.

But if you understand that meaning is built, then there is no single moment when it starts and another when it's done. Every day is an opportunity. Every gesture can be a brick. And your life, as it is now, with everything it has and everything it lacks, is already the ground where meaning can be born.

Frankl said that meaning changes. It changes with age, with circumstances, with the seasons of life. The meaning that sustained your life at twenty is not the same that sustains you at forty. The meaning you found in work can migrate to relationships. The meaning that lived in ambition can transform into service. And none of these changes is a loss. It's an evolution. Meaning is alive. It breathes. It grows. It transforms.

But there is one condition: you have to be present for it. You have to be attentive. You have to be, to some extent, a collaborator in that construction.

And this is where most people get lost. Because we live in such an installed, efficient, implacable autopilot mode that there's almost no space left for the question of meaning. You wake up, function, produce, care, solve, fall asleep, and repeat. And in that cycle there's no space to stop and ask: "What does this mean to me? What am I building with this life? What purpose do I serve, and for whom?"

The construction of meaning asks for something our culture profoundly devalues: slowness. It asks you to stop. To observe. To feel. To ask. It asks you to stop doing long enough to understand why you do what you do.

This is not laziness. This is not a luxury. This is the most essential thing you can do for yourself. Because a life without meaning, however productive, is a life that empties from within. And one day you realize you built everything on the outside and nothing on the inside. And that day hurts.

There is a woman I'll call Sofia. Sofia is thirty-eight and runs a department at a technology company. She is competent, recognized, well paid. Her colleagues admire her. Management trusts her. Her resume is impeccable. And Sofia, every Sunday evening, feels a tightening in her stomach that is not work anxiety. It's something deeper. It's the perception, which she tries to dismiss but that always comes back, that if her department ceased to exist tomorrow, nothing truly important would change in the world.

Sofia doesn't need to change jobs. She needs to find, within what she does or outside it, something that connects her to a deeper reason. Something that answers, even partially, the question: "What is this for, beyond profit, beyond indicators, beyond efficiency?"

That something is meaning. And it's not found in a spectacular career change, nor in a mystical epiphany. It's found, almost always, in the way you look at what already exists and choose to give it significance. In the way you consciously decide to invest your energy in what matters to you. In the way you, one gesture at a time, weave a life that sustains itself from within, even when it looks the same on the outside.

I want to share with you four sources of meaning. Not recipes. Not steps. Territories. Places where meaning tends to be born, to take root, to grow. I call them sources because that is what they are: springs from which something flows that nourishes life from within.

The psychology of meaning, from Frankl to contemporary researchers, identifies these sources in slightly different forms, but the essence is common. I organize them in a way that makes sense (forgive the repetition of the word) from my personal and professional experience. They are four: connection, contribution, transcendence, and presence.

Connection. Meaning is born from connection. From connection to others, to community, to something larger than yourself. No human being builds meaning in isolation. We may be alone and have meaning, but only if that solitude is embedded in a network of relationships that sustains us, even from a distance. The mother who cares for her children finds meaning in the connection to them, not in the task itself. The

woman who works on a project finds meaning when that project connects to real people, real needs, to something that matters beyond herself.

Connection doesn't have to be grand. You don't need to save the world. Sometimes the deepest meaning is born from a simple gesture: looking someone in the eyes and being truly there. Listening without rush. Saying "I'm with you" and meaning exactly that. Connection is relational presence. It's the opposite of the isolation our culture mass-produces, disguised as autonomy and independence.

Contribution. Meaning is born when you feel that what you do matters. That it leaves a mark, however small. That the world, or someone's life, or something, is different because you existed, because you did something, because you dedicated yourself. Contribution is not fame. It's not measurable impact. It's not legacy in the grand sense of the word. It can be the text you wrote that someone read at just the right moment. It can be the conversation you had with your daughter that made her feel less alone. It can be the garden you cultivated, the meal you cooked with love, the way you organized something that needed order.

Contribution answers the question: "What do I offer?" And the answer doesn't need to be spectacular. It needs to be true.

Transcendence. This is the source most difficult to describe, because it escapes words. Transcendence is the moment when you dissolve. When the "I" becomes porous and something larger passes through you. It can happen in nature, when you look at the sea or at a starry sky and feel you are part of something immense. It can happen in meditation, in prayer (if that is your language), in art, in music. It can happen in child-birth, in the death of someone beloved, in deep love. It's the moment when the question "what am I here for?" goes quiet, not because it was answered, but because it stopped making sense, because in that instant you are the answer.

Transcendence is not something you provoke. It's something you allow. That you welcome when it comes. And that reminds us, each time it happens, that there is more in life than what the mind can organize.

Presence. The fourth source is, perhaps, the most radical and the simplest. Presence is being here. Fully. Not in the past, not in the future, not on the to-do list, not in worry. Here. Now. With what is. With what is.

Presence is not a technique. It's a quality of attention. It's the capacity to wash the dishes and be washing the dishes, not mentally solving tomorrow's problems. It's the capacity to listen to your child and truly listen, not with half your mind somewhere else. It's the capacity to feel

the ground beneath your feet, the air entering your lungs, the warmth of the sun on your skin, and recognize that this moment, exactly this one, is your life. Not the preparation for life. Life.

Meaning is born when we are present enough to recognize it. Because meaning doesn't live in the future. It lives here. It always did. But we move so fast we don't see it.

These four sources don't work as a checklist. You don't need all four active at the same time. At different moments in life, one may be more alive than the others. Connection may be your main source while your children are small. Contribution may become central when you enter a project that passionates you. Transcendence may visit you in unexpected moments. Presence may be your refuge on the most difficult days.

What matters is knowing they exist. And that the meaning you're looking for isn't somewhere distant, inaccessible, reserved for the enlightened or the fortunate. It lives in the choices you make every day. In the way you connect, the way you contribute, the way you open yourself to what is larger than you, and the way you inhabit the present moment.

Frankl said something that touches me deeply: "He who has a why to live can bear almost any how." Meaning doesn't eliminate suffering. It doesn't eliminate tiredness, difficulty, pain. But it sustains you. It gives

you roots. It gives you a reason to get up in the morning that doesn't depend on circumstances being perfect.

And that reason, unlike success, doesn't wear down with use. The more you live it, the stronger it becomes. Meaning is not a treadmill. It's a river that flows and, the further you travel it, the deeper it becomes.

But I need to be honest with you about something: understanding this intellectually is not the same as living it. You can read about meaning, agree with everything, and wake up tomorrow with the exact same emptiness. Because meaning is not understood into life. It's practiced. Lived. Embodied. And that process is slower, deeper, more demanding than any reading can offer.

I'm not saying this to discourage you. I'm saying it to prepare you. Because the path of meaning is real, but it's not instant. It's a construction that asks for patience, presence, and, often, company.

And I want to tell you one more thing before we move on: there is no right meaning. There is no universal answer. The meaning of your life is not mine, nor your neighbor's, nor the woman you admire on social media. It's yours. It's born from your history, your wounds, your loves, your losses, your gifts. It's made from the raw material of your life. And for that reason, no one can give it to you. But someone can help you see

it. And that's what I hope to do: not give you answers, but illuminate the ground where your answers are already germinating, even if you can't yet see them.

We'll explore each of these sources in more detail in the next chapter. Not as theory, but as landscape. So that you can recognize yourself in them and, who knows, begin to feel where your own meaning wants to be born.

5. The sources of meaning

Connection: the thread that holds us

I begin with connection, because it seems to me the most urgent. We live in an era that glorifies independence. "I don't need anyone." "I'm enough for myself." "If you want something done right, do it yourself." These phrases sound like strength. But they hide, often, a profound loneliness.

The connection I speak of is not dependence. It's not losing yourself in the other. It's not needing someone else in order to exist. It's something different: knowing that your existence is woven together with other existences. That what you do echoes. That you are not alone in an indifferent universe.

Meaning is born, often, in the moments when we feel we belong. That we are connected to something. It can be to a person: in the gaze of your child when they find you at the school door, in the silent embrace of your partner when neither of you has words, in the friend who calls and says "I was thinking of you," without reason, without explanation. It can be to a community: the group of women who meet on Tuesdays, the team where you feel your contribution matters, the neighbor who le-

aves a lemon cake at your door. It can be to something vaster: to nature, when you look at an ancient tree and feel you're part of the same fabric; to humanity, when you read the story of someone you'll never meet and are moved to tears; to life, simply, when you look at the sky at the end of the day and feel, without explanation, that you are in the right place.

There is a woman I'll call Teresa. Teresa is forty-five, has two teenage children, a stable job in public administration, and a marriage she describes as "functional." Her life, seen from the outside, is perfectly normal. But Teresa feels profoundly lonely. Not because she doesn't have people around her. She does. But because, at some point she can't quite identify, she stopped feeling truly connected to them. Conversations are superficial. Relationships are logistical. The marriage is a co-management of the house and the children. And the loneliness Teresa feels is not that of someone alone in a room. It's that of someone surrounded by people who isn't seen by anyone.

Teresa doesn't need more people. She needs more depth. She needs a space where she can be vulnerable, where she can say "I'm lost" without someone immediately trying to fix it. She needs true connection, and that connection always begins with something frightening: opening up.

True connection requires vulnerability. It requires letting the "I'm fine" mask drop and showing what's underneath. And that's frightening. Because we were taught that showing fragility is dangerous. That those who open up get hurt. That strength is self-containment.

But the truth is that self-containment, taken to the extreme, is a form of isolation. And isolation, however safe it may feel, empties life of meaning. Because meaning is relational. It's born between us, not within us. It's born in the space between two people who truly look at one another.

Contribution: leaving a mark

The second source of meaning is contribution. And here I need to undo a misconception that causes a great deal of suffering: the idea that contributing has to be something grand. That for your life to have meaning, you have to do something extraordinary. Publish a book. Found an institution. Have a visible, measurable, recognized impact.

You don't.

The deepest contribution is, almost always, invisible. It's the mother who teaches her child to be kind, not through sermons, but through daily example. It's the woman who writes in her journal, for herself, and in that act of honesty with herself preserves a truth that may one day il-

illuminate another person. It's the grandmother who cooks with her granddaughters and, without knowing it, is transmitting a ritual of love that will cross generations. It's the work colleague who listens when no one else has the patience to listen.

Contribution is answering, with your life, the question: "What do I give?" Not what you gain, not what you accumulate, not what you achieve. What you give. And this reversal is transformative, because it shifts the center of gravity from you to the other, and in that shift, paradoxically, you find yourself.

Frankl said that meaning is found when we forget ourselves in favor of something or someone. Not in the sense of self-erasure (that's something else, and it's dangerous). In the sense of transcending self-interest. When you are so immersed in what you do that you forget to worry about yourself, when what you give flows without calculation and without expectation of return, then meaning doesn't need to be sought. It's already present.

Think of the moments in your life when you felt most alive. I'd bet many of them involved giving something. A conversation where you helped someone see clearly. A project where you felt you were creating

something that mattered. A moment when your care made a difference in someone's life. They weren't necessarily moments of success. They were moments of contribution. And the difference is enormous.

Transcendence: the moment when the "I" goes quiet

The third source of meaning is the most mysterious. It is also the one that Transpersonal Psychology is most concerned with, and the one closest to my heart, because it was through it that my own relationship with meaning was transformed.

Transcendence is the experience of going beyond the self. Beyond the name, the personal history, the roles, the worries. It is the moment when the boundary between you and the world becomes porous, and something passes through. Something that has no easy name. Something that different traditions call in different ways: the sacred, the divine, the mystery, unity, the Whole. I will not impose any name on you. Use whatever makes sense to you, or none at all.

What matters is not the name. It's the experience.

And the experience is this: there are moments when the question "what is the meaning of my life?" dissolves. Not because it was answered. But because, in that instant, you are not separate from life. You are life. And

when you are life, you don't need to ask what the meaning is, because you are inside it.

It seems abstract. But I'd bet you've felt it. Perhaps while looking at your newborn child and feeling a love so vast it couldn't fit inside your body. Perhaps on a walk in the mountains, when the silence was so deep that something inside you stopped. Perhaps listening to a piece of music that sent shivers through you, or reading a poem that made you cry without knowing why. Perhaps in an embrace, at a sunset, in a moment of prayer or meditation, or simply on an ordinary morning when you looked out the window and, for no apparent reason, everything seemed perfect.

These moments cannot be scheduled. They cannot be forced. They don't obey the will. But we can create the conditions for them to happen more often: through silence, contemplation, contact with nature, art, spiritual practice (whatever yours may be). And each time they happen, they leave a trace. A trace of quiet certainty: there is more than this. More than the routine, more than the problems, more than the small self with its worries. There is something vast, and I am part of it.

Transcendence doesn't solve the problems of daily life. It doesn't pay the bills or do the laundry. But it gives you a perspective that changes everything. Because when you know, in the body and not only in the

head, that you are part of something larger, the everyday ceases to be merely everyday. It becomes the place where the sacred manifests, disguised as the ordinary.

Abraham Maslow, the psychologist who studied what he called "peak experiences," discovered that people who had these experiences regularly (not necessarily religious people, but people open to mystery) had a different relationship with life. They felt more connected, more creative, more compassionate. And, crucially, they had more meaning.

Not because meaning had been given to them. But because they had glimpsed something that made the question of meaning less urgent and, at the same time, more profound. As if they had seen, for an instant, the whole landscape, and now each step on the path made more sense, even without knowing where they were going.

Presence: the quietest source

The fourth source is presence. And it is, in a certain sense, the most difficult. Not because it's complicated. Because it's too simple for our complicated minds.

Being present is being here. That seems obvious. But think about how many hours of your day you actually spend here. Not in the past (ruminating on what happened, blaming yourself for what you did or didn't do). Not in the future (planning, anticipating, worrying). Here. With what's happening now.

Most of us live on autopilot. We get up, dress, eat, drive, work, care, fall asleep, and repeat. And amid all of this, life happens without us witnessing it. We are present in body, but absent in spirit. And life, lived without presence, is like a film playing while we look at our phones. It happens. But we didn't watch it.

Presence is the decision to witness your own life. To truly be where you are. To not add to the present moment a narrative of insufficiency ("this isn't enough," "it should be different," "when does the good part begin?").

Presence returns to us something that existential emptiness steals: the capacity to recognize that life, as it is, already contains what we seek. Not as a comforting idea, but as direct experience. When you are truly present for your child's embrace, you don't need anything more in that moment. When you are truly present with the taste of your morning coffee, the light coming through the window, the sound of the rain, there is a fullness that doesn't depend on external circumstances.

This is not toxic positivity. I'm not telling you to ignore problems and pretend everything is fine. I'm telling you there is a dimension of experience that is always available, even on the most difficult days: the dimension of being alive, here, now. And that this dimension, when it is recognized, when it is inhabited, is an inexhaustible source of meaning.

Because the deepest meaning perhaps doesn't lie in great achievements, in conquests, in feats. Perhaps it lives in the simplest gesture: being here. Fully. With what is. Without fleeing. Without adding. Without subtracting.

Simply being.

There is a woman I know who once told me: "I spent years looking for the meaning of my life as though I were looking for my keys. I looked everywhere. I turned everything upside down. I got more and more frustrated. Until one day I stopped. And I realized the keys were in my pocket. They always had been. I was just so busy looking that I never stopped to feel them." She didn't find meaning in a great moment of revelation. She found it on a Wednesday morning, drinking tea in the kitchen, listening to the birds, doing nothing. She found it in presence. And from then on, the meaning didn't disappear, because it didn't depend on circumstances. It depended on attention.

These four sources (connection, contribution, transcendence, and presence) are not separate compartments. They interweave, they nourish one another. A mother who is truly present with her child (presence) feels the depth of connection (connection), realizes she is contributing to the shaping of a human being (contribution), and sometimes, in that simple moment, touches something that goes beyond both of them (transcendence). The sources are not separate destinations. They are rivers that flow into the same sea.

And in that being, something settles. Something that was seeking without knowing what it sought finds, without knowing what it found. And the void, which seemed infinite, reveals itself as the space where life can, finally, breathe.

6. The crossing that awaits you

We've reached the end of these pages. But not the end of the path. In fact, if this book did what I hoped it would do, the path is only now becoming visible.

You now know some things that before, perhaps, you felt but couldn't name. You know the emptiness you feel is not ingratitude, not weakness, not a defect. It's the natural response of a soul asking for meaning in a world that offers it success. You know that meaning isn't found like a lost object, but is built, day by day, choice by choice. You know there are sources, interior territories, where meaning springs forth: connection, contribution, transcendence, presence. And you know this path, though demanding, is profoundly human.

That is already a great deal. Understanding is the first step. And understanding, in itself, already changes something. It changes the way you look at yourself. It changes the way you look at the emptiness. Instead of an enemy, it becomes a messenger. Instead of a problem, it becomes an invitation.

But (and I say this with all honesty, because I respect you too much to give you half-truths) understanding alone is not enough to transform.

You can understand that meaning is built and not know where to begin. You can recognize the sources and not know how to open them in your concrete life. You can have seen the map and still need company to walk the path. Because there are interior territories that aren't crossed alone. There are deeper layers of ourselves that need a safe space, guidance, someone who knows the terrain.

This is not failure. This is being human. And it is, truly, one of the most profound ways to honor this path: recognizing that it asks more than your mind, alone, can offer.

My writing, my texts (the pieces I share on the site, the words I leave there for whoever needs them), are a thread in that crossing. They are pieces of my own path that I offer so they might illuminate a stretch of yours. If these pages made sense to you, there is more. There are texts born from a place similar to this one, with the same honesty, with the same refusal to give easy answers. They are at viviannedossantos.com, waiting for you, without rush.

And there is a space I created for those who feel that understanding was important, but who want to go deeper. The Escola dos Véus is that space. Not a course. Not a personal development program with promises and schedules. It's a place of deep exploration, where the questions this book raised can be lived, not just read. Where meaning isn't discus-

sed in the abstract, but touched with the hands of the soul. Where transcendence, presence, connection, and contribution cease to be concepts and become experience.

I won't promise you that there you'll find answers to everything. Life doesn't work that way, and I refuse to promise what I cannot guarantee. What I can tell you is that it was built with the same care I put into these pages. With the same conviction that you are not empty: you are searching. And the search, when it is honest, when it is accompanied, when it is done with respect for your pace and your truth, is itself full of meaning.

If you feel it's the moment, the Escola dos Véus is waiting for you.

If it's not the moment, that's perfectly fine. Keep this book. Reread it when the question comes back (and it will come back, because it's a living question, and living questions don't go quiet). Let the ideas settle. Sometimes the seed needs time and silence before it can germinate.

But I want to ask you one thing before you close this page.

Today, today still, stop for a moment. Not to do anything. To be. To feel the ground beneath your feet, the air entering your lungs, the weight of your body in the chair. Feel that you are here. That you are alive. That

this moment, this exact one, with everything it has and everything it lacks, is your life. Not the preparation for life. Life.

And in that brief instant of presence, perhaps you'll feel something that doesn't need a name. Something that is not conquered, not bought, not reached. Something that simply is, when you allow yourself to stop long enough to recognize it.

That something is the beginning of meaning.

And it is already yours.

With all my tenderness, *Vivianne*

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